Blues Ain't Nothin but a Good Woman Feelin Bad

By Shay Youngblood

MISS BLUE: *(singing and upbeat)* ***The Blues Ain't Nothin but a woman wanna see her man . . .*** *(repeat)**

NARRATOR: **(Pg 61-66)** Miss Blue lived down the block. She useta sit on her front porch watching TV from eight o'clock in the morning till near dark. First thing in the morning she come out her door in a short housedress in summer, or a raggedy wool robe in winter, with pink sponge hair rollers in her short graying hair. She would haul out her lil black-and-white TV and put it on top of the big gray metal garbage can two feet in front of her.

[And] At night I'd hear her singing the blues. [She] used to sing the blues for a living till her heart started failing. She'd lived through three heart attacks. [One day] something set Miss Blue off on the past and she started talking about love and pain. The way she talked, there wasn't one without the other.

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INTRODUCTION

During the 1930s, The Blues was music created by African Americans of the Deep South. It was the music of front porches and ramshackle juke joints that encouraged dancing, drinking and music. It was the music of love and pain.

Musician Wynton Marsalis once said, "Everything comes out in blues music: joy, pain, struggle. Blues is affirmation with absolute elegance. It's about a man and a woman. So, the pain and the struggle in the blues is that universal pain that comes from having your heart broken."

And Miss Blue's heart ***was*** *broken . . .*

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MISS BLUE: I been in love too many times to count. If love was a dollar bill I'd be a millionaire, and if pain was a quarter it'd be triple. All I got now is my memories – some good, some bad. Like June of 1923.

Me and Bo Willie Peeks met in a juke joint I was singing in. I wasn't no more than twenty-four or twenty-five years old, and he was the first man I really let love me and the first man I truly give my heart and soul to. Now there was plenty mens round. Mens that made me feel

like a star. But Bo Willie took my mind. When I met him, he was married and tipping out on his wife. I never figured he'd tip out on me, and that was my downfall. *(hums softly as she imagines herself on stage)*

He would sit at a table up front. Chills run up and down my spine when I catch his eyes all over me. Wasn't long before he was waiting for me after the show. One night he come up to me at the bar and he says,

BO WILLIE: Hey sweetmeat, what's cooking?

MISS BLUE: I didn't know what he was talking bout. I wasn't hip then. I was so nervous, sweat start popping off my face.

BO WILLIE: You what's cooking, sugar pie. Your cooking is fine as wine and you look good enough to eat, mama.

MISS BLUE: That man drowned me with sweet words and kindness. Treat me like a queen. I wasn't useta that kinda treatment. You see I knowed I was jet black and didn't have no hips and wasn't particularly pretty, but he made me feel like I was the most beautiful Black creature breathing air, and I almost believed him. He was the one made me feel like I was somebody special.

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Don't get me wrong, he wasn't nowhere near perfect. He drank a lil, and he'd be mean to me, call me an ugly baboon, or talk bout my bug eyes. But usually he was good to me. He begged me on his hands and knees to marry him. I didn't really feel ready, but he kept on bout how good we was together, how much he love me, and how much he could do for me. After awhile love did cloud my eyes up.

Bo Willie got a good-paying job on the railroad and said he was ready to settle down with me. [So] finally I give in and told him I'd marry him. Chile, he was my thunder and honey. He was all I could see, smell, taste, or touch. We made plans to get married the day he got back from a three-week trip up to New York. I was so happy I smiled all the time, and strangers on the street started asking me if I was in love. I couldn't do nothing but shake my head and grin . . . He called me that first week saying he was lonesome.

BO WILLIE: *(teasing)* These gals in New York bout to drive me crazy. A man cain't go to a bar for a drink without em all over me.

MISS BLUE: *(also teasing)* I hope you tell em you good as married.

BO WILLIE: *(laughing)* I do, but it don't matter none to these gals in New York.

MISS BLUE: I wasn't worried. He was a good man. Told me he was tired of running round and wanted a wife and a settled life, and I was ready to kiss his feets and bear him a house full of children. [So] I went shopping for my wedding dress – a real expensive white woold suit with pearl buttons – and white gloves, shoes, pocketbook, and hat to match.

The day Bo Willie was to arrive at my mama's house for the wedding, one hour before the preacher and guests was to come, [he] call me and told me he had another gal. His words cut me to the bone. He say he still love me, but he met this woman. He say he didn't want me to marry him and be miserable. Hmph!

I loved that man so much I told him I didn't care bout no other woman, I'd take him like he was if only he'd come to the house that minute and say yes before the preacher. He said he was still in New York and didn't

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know if he was really ready to settle down. I ask him if I could come where he was so we could talk, and he flat-out refused. Then I got mad, remembering his sweet lies of loving me to the grave.

(with growing anger) Bo Willie, you a no-good lying dog. If you was on fire, I wouldn't waste my spit on you. I hope you die choking on your own vomit. You have made a hard bed, now lay in it. You gonna be sorry through, you gonna miss me. Everything you touch is gonna turn to s***, dry up like dust and blow on the wind.

I slammed the phone down and cried for two days solid. For a week I didn't sleep, eat more than a slice of dry bread and a half cup of coffee. Food lumped up in my throat thinking bout him with another woman. I wanted him dead, boiling in his own blood. I wanted him to hurt my hurt.

One night I was walking the streets, going from joint to joint trying to find him, and I saw him. He was by hisself, getting outta a brand new fishtail Cadillac. I

rushed over to the car and swung open the door on his side. I know I scared him cause I looked like a haint. My hair was standing up on my head, I hadn't changed my clothes for three days, and my eyes had murder in em. I snatched him out the car and was quick on him like white on rice. I hadn't had no food in days but I found the strength to knock him on the ground. Then I got in the car, shifted in reverse, and tried to run him down like the dog he was. He was lucky I smashed into a telephone pole fore I flattened his a**. I just broke his leg and run over his foot.

I got out the car and walked home with my head up. Took a long hot bath and lit a seven-day candle to ask to be released from him and get my mind back. But I left part of me back at that wreck. *(beat)* Love hurt. I really had something to sing the blues bout then. That same year I made a hit record, my only record, 'The Blues Ain't Nothin but a Good Woman Feeling Bad.' (long beat)

I heard a few months after I wrecked his car that the woman he was with took all his money and left him and

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he lost his job on the railroad. *(pause)* You know something, I hope to this day that sorry son-of-a-b**** is still sucking rocks. One good thing done come out of all that though, and that was a song. It was blue but it was a song. A damn good one, too. . . *(she begins to sing low and sadly this time)* ***The Blues Ain't Nothin but a woman wanna see her man . . .*** *(repeat)**

NATIONAL

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
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** Music and Lyrics to*
The Blues Ain't Nothin' by Georgia White:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H2XaFXXuolk